

Exam 4 Study Guide: Morality and Global Aid

Garrett Hardin & Peter Singer

This exam evaluates your ability to **reconstruct philosophical arguments** clearly and rigorously using your own words while staying faithful to the authors' views. Below you'll find the conceptual points you must understand for each section, plus guidance on the argumentative function required for each blank.

I. Garrett Hardin – “*Lifeboat Ethics: The Case Against Helping the Poor*”

Topic: Whether wealthy nations have moral obligations to aid poorer ones.

Hardin's essay is a **critique of humanitarian aid** framed through his metaphors of the **spaceship** and the **lifeboat**. You must understand his central analogy and how he uses it to argue that aiding the poor leads to catastrophic consequences.

1. Opening Claim (Thesis)

Function: State Hardin's core thesis about why the “spaceship Earth” metaphor is misleading and dangerous.

Key Points to Include:

- Spaceship metaphor suggests unified control, shared responsibility, and a central authority.
- Hardin rejects this and prefers the “lifeboat” metaphor: rich nations are in lifeboats while poor nations are in the water.
- The danger is that treating the world as a spaceship obscures finite resources and leads to destructive sharing policies.

2. Reason: Why unrestricted generosity destroys both rich and poor

Function: Give the causal reasoning behind Hardin's warning.

Key Points:

- Carrying capacity: lifeboats have limits; adding too many will sink the boat.
- Aid encourages population growth and resource depletion.
- Without enforcing limits, the result is mutual ruin ("the tragedy of the commons").

3. Counterpoint or Tension

Function: Present the moral impulse many people feel to help those in need.

Key Points:

- Sympathy for the suffering is natural and morally praiseworthy.
- Many believe that wealthy nations have a humanitarian obligation or global justice duty to share abundance.

4. Response / Transition

Function: Show how Hardin answers that moral impulse.

Key Points:

- Hardin argues that good intentions without ecological thinking produce disastrous outcomes.
- A responsible ethic must consider long-term survival, not short-term compassion.

5. Conclusion

Function: State Hardin's evaluative recommendation.

Key Points:

- Wealthy nations ought not pursue aid policies that jeopardize their own survival.

- Strict limits—possibly even refusing aid—are morally required to prevent global catastrophe.
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II. Peter Singer – “*Famine, Affluence, and Morality*”

Topic: What morality requires of affluent individuals with respect to global poverty.

Singer’s essay is built around a **single moral principle** and a highly intuitive thought experiment. Your answers should reflect how Singer **reconstructs commonsense morality** and challenges conventional views of charity.

1. Opening Claim: Singer’s Guiding Moral Principle

Function: Clearly introduce the principle.

Key Points:

- If we can prevent something bad from happening without sacrificing anything of comparable moral significance, we morally ought to do it.
- This principle is impartial and demands action whenever severe suffering can be alleviated at low cost.

2. The Drowning Child Example

Function: Describe the case and the intuitive judgment it aims to elicit.

Key Points:

- You see a child drowning in a shallow pond; saving the child ruins your clothes but costs little else.
- Morally, you should save the child; failing to do so is unthinkable.
- Singer uses this to show how straightforward our intuitions are when the case is vivid

and immediate.

3. Application to Global Poverty

Function: Explicitly draw the analogy and explain why distance is irrelevant.

Key Points:

- The global poor are just as morally significant as the drowning child.
- Physical distance or the presence of many other potential helpers does not diminish one's obligation.
- Technology and global interdependence make aid possible with minimal cost.

4. Philosophical Implication: Charity vs. Duty

Function: Explain how Singer's argument revises our moral categories.

Key Points:

- We usually treat giving to the poor as supererogatory—good but not required.
- Singer argues this distinction is unjustified: if we can prevent suffering without comparable sacrifice, it is a **duty**.
- Our current patterns of spending are morally indefensible by this standard.

5. Conclusion: What Morality Demands of the Affluent

Function: Articulate Singer's prescriptive conclusion.

Key Points:

- The affluent must radically revise their moral priorities and give much more to effective aid.
- Morality demands substantial, ongoing sacrifice until we reach a point of diminishing marginal utility.

How to Use This Study Guide Effectively

- For each blank on the exam, identify the **argumentative function** (claim, reason, counterpoint, transition, conclusion).
- Write in **full sentences** that clearly express philosophical reasoning.
- Avoid quoting the authors; instead, **paraphrase accurately**.
- Maintain argumentative coherence: each sentence must logically follow from the last.
- Keep your focus on what the philosopher themselves argues—not your own views.